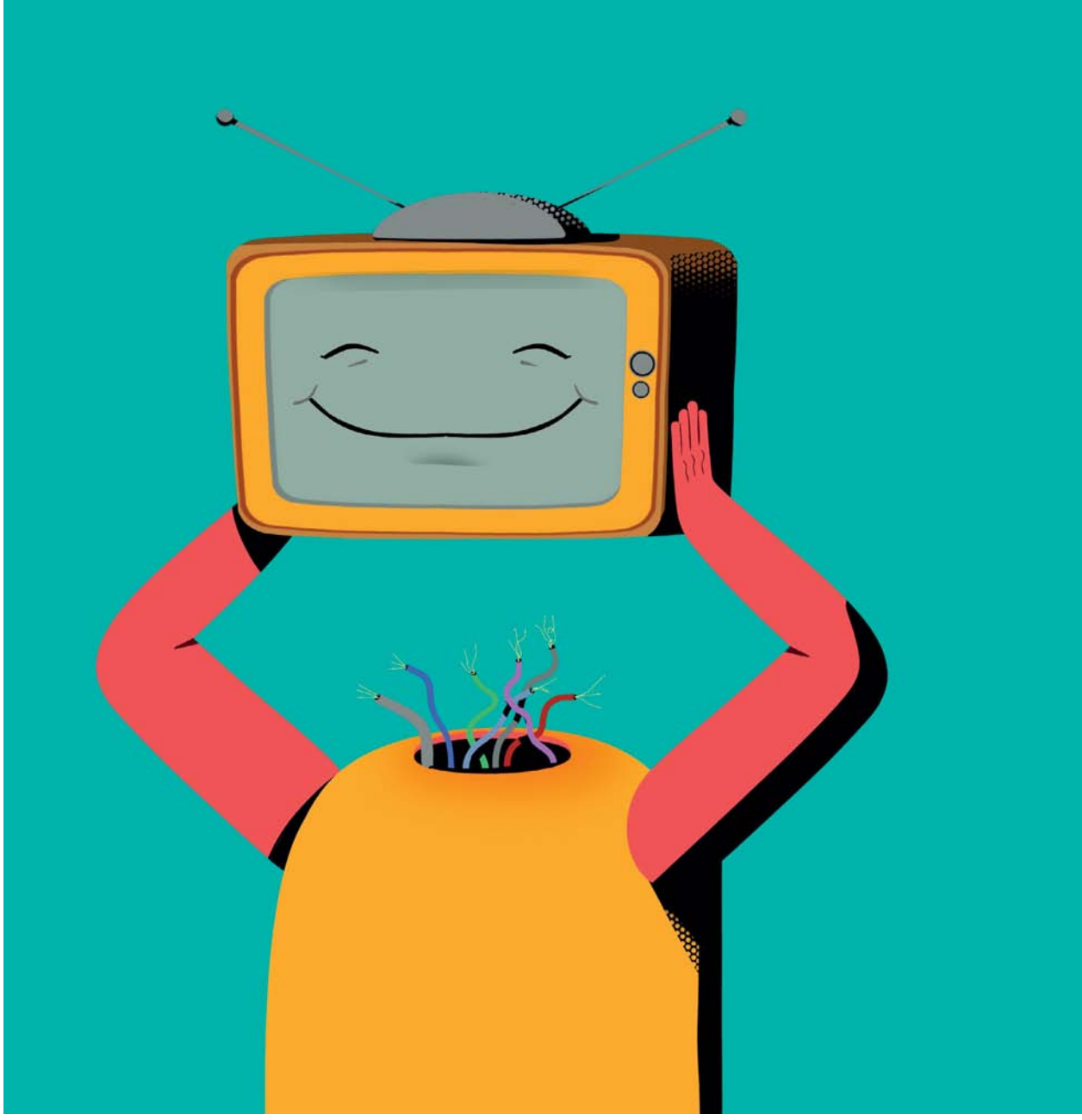


Illustration by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

box office and attracting even higher footfalls than they might have prior to the pandemic. On the other hand, dramas, light comedies, rom-coms and more nuanced and layered narratives seem to have now become the almost exclusive preserve of the home-viewing experience. This shift was underway even before COVID-19, but the starkness of the contrast between the underwhelming theatrical performance of some genres compared to the over-performance of others is now crystal clear. There will always be exceptions to this rule, because as William Goldman astutely said, "Nobody really knows anything in the motion picture business." But the hard facts of the polarised box-office performance across genres will—at least in the short to medium term—greatly influence the creative choices made by studios, streamers, producers, directors and artists, about which projects to greenlight for theatrical and which for non-theatrical platforms.

While gaming has been a huge industry for many years now (many times the size of the movie business), I foresee a huge confluence between the traditional entertainment industry and the gaming industry in the years to come. Younger audiences are now used to having much more control over their narrative choices, whether it be on social media, in gaming or in the fledgling metaverse, and this is bound to reflect in their need to take control of their entertainment narratives, too. There have been experiments in binary choice-based narratives for a few years now (the 2018 *Black Mirror: Bandersnatch* on Netflix, for example), but I foresee a future in which audiences actively take on the role of protagonists in AR/VR-assisted layered narratives with fully realised emotional choices that drive the progression of the plot. This might still be a few years into the future, but it seems inevitable that with technology